people, because on the way to his Pothigai hermitage he encounters Lord Shiva's son Murugan in the guise of an old man, who teaches him various arts that subsequently become integral to Tamil culture: astronomy, healing and harming – the last becoming the Keralan martial art of *kalarippayattu*, said (by Keralans) to be the 'mother of all martial arts'.

This sounds very much like a Tamil version of the Biblical story of Moses leading the children of Israel to the promised land – and there may well be something in that parallel.

The first Western scholar to attempt to reconcile these two versions of Agastya/Agathya was, of course, Robert Caldwell. He has subsequently been castigated for dating Tholkappiyar's *Tolkappiyam* grammar to the tenth century, but the point he wanted to make was that the Tamil Agastya appears on the literary scene long after the Sanskrit Agastya. Caldwell went on to suggest that the latter was essentially a Tamil response to the intrusion of Sanskrit culture on the South and that he may not have been a living person but more likely Tamil culture's 'mythological embodiment'.

Caldwell had a very high opinion of Tamils as 'the least superstitious and the most enterprising and persevering race of Hindus' and he spoke highly of their culture. Even so, he had no hesitation in stating that what he called the Tamil people's 'higher civilisation' was derived from the Sanskrit North, more specifically from 'a succession of small colonies of Aryans, chiefly Brahmins, from Upper India, who were probably attracted to the South by the report of the fertility of the rich alluvial plains watered by the Kaveri, the Thamirabarani, and the other peninsula rivers'.

These views soon came under attack. One of Caldwell's most outspoken opponents was a former student of a Christian college named Arumuka Navalar, a non-Brahmin born into a literary Pillai family and brought up in the Tamil-dominated Jaffna peninsula in Ceylon. Navalar had helped